

Finding the Tower

The woods have grown much denser in my long absence. The ash trees crowd the old path like they're guarding a tomb. Frankly, they *are* guarding a tomb. I passed more than a handful of dead soldiers on my way here. I am to replace them, to so terrify any would-be travelers that any enemy scouts from the river are forced northward. I have two months to set up defenses so I better get to work. I doubt I'll have a chance to write much in the interim. The cost of bold promises I suppose.

The regular soldiers are afraid of me, but that was always part of the deal. What remains truly valuable is the solitude. No auditors lurking in the sills, no senior magus hovering at the back of my lectures scribbling like a damned stenographer, no whelps asking for extra credit. Just this little crooked tower, all to myself. I think my old master would approve—she always did say that obscurity is the best protection for the dangerous and the brilliant. Fame has its uses, as does infamy, I did well in my past life and my contacts in Elga Elluin have already promised a regular courier.

The tower itself is cramped. My master once called it “humble,” but that was only because she couldn't bring herself to say “provincial.” Still, it stands, and—thanks to her obsession with earthquake-proof architecture—it stands in better shape than I expected. It's almost a shame that I really do need to scrap it and start from scratch to fit my needs, though that's a job for another year. The front door responded to my backup sigil after only a little coaxing. The interior is perfectly intact in that way abandoned things often are: dusty, silent, waiting to be bothered. I'll animate some brooms to do a little dusting while I take inventory of the Hold. There has to be something useful in there.